



▲ CHANG'AN

In the 7th century, the Tang capital Chang'an (present-day Xi'an) was the world's most populous city, with around one million people living within its city walls and another million in the suburbs beyond. Dating from this time, the Giant Wild Goose Pagoda (above) still stands today. It was built to store Buddhist sacred texts.

Tang and Song China

After the fall of the Han Dynasty in the 3rd century CE, China experienced centuries of unrest. But in 618, the rebel leader Li Yuan set up the Tang Dynasty, which lasted until 907. Another period of turmoil followed before the general Zhao Kuangyin established the Song Dynasty (960–1279). Historians see both of these periods as high points of Chinese civilization.

In the Tang era, the development of woodblock printing in the 7th century allowed the publication of many new texts, helping to improve literacy. China began expanding its control to the west and south, and soon became a powerful influence over neighboring Japan and Korea.

Thanks in part to improved methods of growing rice, the population of China grew rapidly during the Song period, reaching 200 million people by

the end of the dynasty in 1279. This population growth allowed Song China to prosper economically and a new merchant class emerged. Technology also flourished under the Song, with many new inventions and discoveries.

Under both dynasties, emperors ruled with the help of an efficient civil service—government employees who administered the laws of the country.

